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Digital Wellbeing for Instructors and Students

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Let's talk about something many of us experience but don't always acknowledge: digital fatigue. Whether you're teaching, learning, or juggling both, the day can feel like a constant stream of notifications and tasks. Long video sessions and extended screen time only add to the mental load. If you've ever ended the day feeling mentally drained from "just being online," you're not imagining it. Even when we haven't moved much physically, our brains have been switching tasks, responding to alerts, and making constant micro-decisions. That sustained cognitive load adds up. Research shows that excessive and unstructured digital engagement is linked to increased stress, reduced focus and resilience, and physical symptoms like eye strain and fatigue (An et al., 2025; Neagu & Vieriu, 2025).

The good news is that small, intentional adjustments can make a real difference. Practicing digital self-care, like stepping away from your screen, taking breaks, and setting clear boundaries, helps you protect your energy and show up at your best. Digital wellbeing isn't about rejecting technology. It's about using digital tools in ways that support mental health, focus, and sustainable engagement.

Use the strategies below to prioritize your wellbeing while modeling and encouraging healthy digital habits for your students.

1

TIME-BLOCK YOUR WORK AND MUTE NOTIFICATIONS.

Ever find yourself checking email or eCampus updates every five minutes? It's draining. Research shows that constant interruptions reduce cognitive focus and increase stress (Human Clarity Institute, 2025). Instead, try creating dedicated grading or prep blocks and silencing notifications while you work. Even 30-60 minutes of uninterrupted time can significantly improve productivity and reduce mental fatigue. Your brain (and your to-do list) will notice the difference.

2

TAKE A MOVEMENT OR MINDFULNESS BREAK EVERY 90 MINUTES.

Sitting at a screen for hours isn't just tiring. It affects mood, attention, posture, and energy levels. Research shows that short breaks, like

standing up, stretching, stepping outside, or taking a few mindful breaths can boost focus and restore energy (Metta Wellbeing, 2025).

Tip: Set a timer or use a technique like Pomodoro. Try 30-90 minutes of focused work followed by a short reset. Move your body. Step outside. Look away from your screen. Even a few minutes can make a difference. Check out [Pomodoro Timer](#), for a free online tool.

3

KEEP VIDEO SESSIONS SHORT AND ENGAGING.

Attention naturally declines during long meetings or lectures. Designing sessions in shorter segments, with interactive moments every 10-15 minutes, helps sustain focus and reduce cognitive fatigue. Think polls, reflection pauses, quick chat prompts, or brief discussion breaks. These small shifts can significantly improve engagement and retention. Adult learners consistently demonstrate stronger

outcomes in shorter, more interactive sessions than in marathon online meetings.

4

SET AND COMMUNICATE ONLINE BOUNDARIES.

How often do you feel pressure to respond to emails immediately, even after hours? You're not alone. Clear boundaries around availability reduce stress and set healthy expectations for students. Research shows that mindful digital patterns, rather than constant checking, protect mental wellbeing (Bhat, et al., 2025).

Tip: Share your “office hours” and email response windows in your syllabus or in eCampus. Modeling boundaries gives students permission to create their own.

5

ENCOURAGE YOUR STUDENTS TO DO THE SAME.



Digital wellbeing is contagious, in a good way! Invite students to reflect on their own tech habits. Are they multitasking during lectures? Taking breaks? Managing notifications? Simple strategies, like limiting digital distractions and building short resets into study time, can improve focus and learning outcomes (Martin et al., 2025). When we normalize these conversations, we help students build habits that extend beyond one course and into their broader academic and professional lives.

6

USE WELLBEING TOOLS AND WVU RESOURCES.

Technology can also be part of the solution. Apps offer guided meditation, stress relief exercises, and sleep tools that are shown to support psychological wellbeing.

Visit [Carruth Center Online Resources at West Virginia University](#), for a curated list

of recommended wellbeing apps and online resources for additional support.

At WVU, you're not navigating this alone. Students, faculty, and staff can access [YOU at WVU](#), a confidential, personalized platform that delivers curated wellbeing content and connects users to supportive campus services in one easy-to-access place.

Check out [The Carruth Center for Counseling & Psychological Services at West Virginia University](#) for information about short-term counseling and crisis support.

Additional Resources for Students:

- [BetterMynd](#) (via WVU partnership - WVU Students Only): Free, confidential virtual counseling that offers flexible support from licensed mental health professionals.
- [Student Emotional Wellbeing Badge](#): Self-paced program to build resilience and stress management skills.
- [WELLWVU Programs & Resources](#): Stress management, wellness challenges, and campus resource guides.

For additional resources and student support, check out the [CAHS Online Students: Getting Help](#).

Additional Resource for Faculty & Staff

- [Faculty & Staff Assistance Program \(FSAP\)](#): Counseling and support for work-life balance.

Sharing these tools and resources helps normalize conversations about mental health and digital wellbeing, making it easier for everyone to seek support when needed.

Final Thoughts

Digital wellbeing isn't about avoiding screens. It's about being intentional with how we use them. By modeling healthy tech habits, building in mindful breaks, designing engaging sessions, and sharing available resources, we can create learning environments that support both performance and wellbeing. Small adjustments matter. A muted notification, a shorter lecture segment, a five-minute reset. Over time, these choices build a learning environment where focus, performance, and wellbeing thrive together.

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Related Articles

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- [Start Where Students Start: Using the WVU Digital Accessibility Word Guide](#)
- [Cue the Game Film: Your End-of-Term Course Audit](#)
- [Simplify Accessibility Checks with Grackle](#)
- [Show What You Know: Help Students Earn the College Student Guide to AI Badge](#)

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